



Ethicare Resourcing

AUSTRALIAN CAPITAL TERRITORY GUIDE · 2026



RELOCATION GUIDE

Canberra

Ngunnawal Country

A relocation guide for healthcare professionals and their families. The work, the neighbourhoods, the money and the weekends in Canberra.

The bush capital. Built for a good life.

Canberra is the Australian capital built on purpose: a lake at its heart, bush-covered hills on every side and a calm, well-planned city that gives you your time back. For clinicians it offers one territory-wide health system with a referral reach far beyond its size, some of the shortest commutes on the mainland, and the snow, the coast and wine country all within an easy drive.

~480,000

people in the ACT

~20 min

most districts to most workplaces

~2.5 hrs

to the Snowy Mountains ski fields

Nearly half

of the territory is national park or reserve

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Guides describe places, not employers. Hospitals are described rather than named, and salaries, visas and registration rules change, so we confirm the detail with you directly.

Why clinicians choose Canberra

Canberra tends to win people over twice: first with how well the plan still works, and then with how much life fits around a working week.



If you're looking for big-city buzz and a huge professional scene, Canberra may not be it. But if you're drawn to calm streets, short commutes, a lake at the heart of the city and the snow within a day trip, it could be a great choice.

Canberra is Australia's largest inland city and the only one built from scratch to be the capital. Walter Burley Griffin's competition-winning plan, from 1913, still shapes it: an artificial lake at the centre, the national institutions along its southern shore, and a ring of planned town centres, each with its own shops, schools and services, threaded with bush reserves and hills you can walk up before work.

For clinicians the offer is unusual. The territory runs public health as **one system** rather than several competing networks, and that system is the specialist referral centre for a wide stretch of southern New South Wales, so the caseload reaches well beyond the city's own population. Average incomes are the highest of any Australian state or territory, there are no toll roads anywhere in the ACT, and most people live twenty-odd minutes from work.

One more detail surprises almost everyone who checks it: despite being the seat of federal government, Canberra is classed as a **regional area for skilled migration**, in the same bracket as Perth, Adelaide and Hobart. Your migration adviser can tell you exactly what that means for your visa pathway.

WHAT YOU GAIN

Time back every day

Wide, uncrowded roads, no tolls and short distances. A commute locals call long would feel ordinary almost anywhere else.

Work bigger than the city

Trauma, cardiac, cancer and other specialist services take referrals from across southern NSW, giving you a richer case mix than the population suggests.

Nature on the doorstep

The lake loop, Black Mountain and Mount Ainslie sit inside the city, and Namadgi National Park begins just south of the suburbs.

GOOD TO KNOW

Calm by design

Canberra is elegant rather than electric. For a big night out or a major concert, Sydney is three hours up the road or a short flight.

Crisp, frosty winters

Four real seasons, with frosty mornings in winter. Choose a warm, well-insulated home and you will enjoy the clear, sunny days.

The coast is a weekend drive

The nearest beaches are about two hours away on the NSW South Coast, which makes them a favourite weekend escape rather than an everyday one.

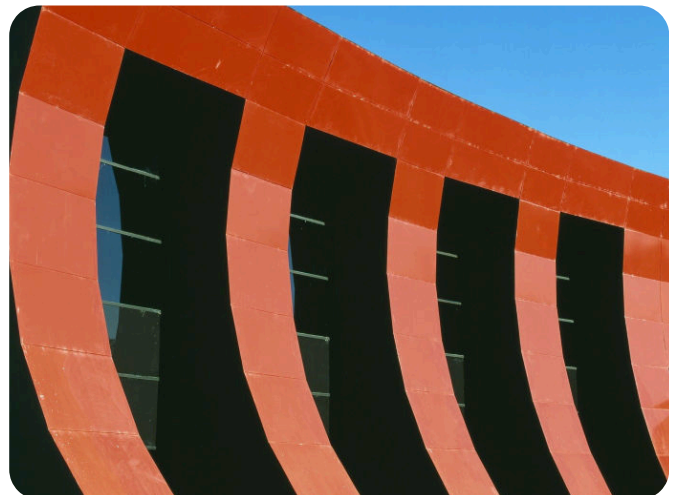
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Weighing up your options?

People often compare Canberra with Sydney or Melbourne, for scale and sub-specialty depth; Brisbane, for warm winters and the coast close by; and Adelaide, for everyday affordability. Canberra usually offers the easiest daily life of the group, with the most time left over. We are happy to talk any of them through.



Parliament House: the city's best-known building, and one many new arrivals tour in their first month



The bold architecture of the National Museum of Australia, one of the national institutions around the lake

A planned city around a lake

A lake at the centre, a ring of hills and reserves around it, and town centres built to a human scale. Once you understand the plan, everything in Canberra is easy to find.

Lake Burley Griffin, completed in 1964, sits exactly where Griffin's plan put it. Along its southern shore runs the Parliamentary Triangle: Parliament House, Old Parliament House, the National Gallery, the National Library and the High Court, all within a stroll of the water, with the National Museum and the Australian War Memorial a short walk or ride away.

Around this centre the city grew as a series of planned districts: the inner north (Braddon, Dickson, O'Connor, Ainslie) and inner south (Kingston, Manuka, Griffith), then Belconnen, Woden, Weston Creek and Tuggeranong further out, with Gungahlin and the Molonglo Valley the newest areas. Black Mountain and Mount Ainslie rise right inside the suburbs, and Namadgi National Park, covering close to half of the territory, begins just to the south. Queanbeyan, in New South Wales, sits just over the border and is very much part of everyday Canberra life.



Lake Burley Griffin and the Captain Cook Memorial Jet, with the Brindabella Ranges on the horizon



The lakeside path: half the city seems to use it before work

Summer

DEC - FEB

Warm, dry and sunny, with daytime highs around 28°C and the odd hotter spell. Long evenings by the lake and outdoor cinema season.

Autumn

MAR - MAY

Still, golden days around 19°C and cool nights. The European trees planted through the original plan turn the city red and gold.

Winter

JUN - AUG

Crisp and clear, around 12°C by day with frosty mornings. Snow in the city is rare, but the ski fields are a day trip away.

Spring

SEP - NOV

Blossom along the streets, highs around 20°C, and Floriade, one of the Southern Hemisphere's biggest flower festivals, in Commonwealth Park.

Canberra has a genuine four-season continental climate: drier and sunnier than the coastal capitals, warmer in summer and crisper in winter. Scraping frost off the windscreen is a normal winter morning, so a well-heated home matters. In summer, take total fire ban days seriously, as you would anywhere in inland Australia.

It is also a more international city than its size suggests. Around ninety countries have an embassy or high commission here, mostly in Yarralumla, Forrest and O'Malley, which brings cultural events, international schools and a wide mix of restaurants and communities.

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Ngunnawal Country

Canberra takes its name from a local word broadly meaning "meeting place". The Ngunnawal people are recognised as the Traditional Custodians of the region, and the Ngambri people also hold a recognised connection to Country. Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings and events across the territory, and several reserves and the National Arboretum run Ngunnawal-led programmes that are a lovely way to learn about the land you now live on.

Words you'll hear in week one



The bush capital: Canberra's own nickname, and an accurate one.



The Parliamentary Triangle: the national institutions along the lake's southern shore.



MyWay+: the territory's public transport fare system for buses and light rail.



Floriade: the spring flower festival that takes over Commonwealth Park.



Over the border: Queanbeyan and the NSW towns just outside the ACT.

Healthcare in Canberra

Registration is national, but working here has its own character: one territory-wide public system, serving a catchment far bigger than the city itself.

The ACT runs public health as a single territory-wide service rather than dividing the city into competing networks, as the larger states do. It has two public hospital campuses: a large tertiary teaching campus in the south, which has recently gained a major new critical services building, and a second campus in the north, both run by the territory. A dedicated rehabilitation hospital sits on a university campus, and community health centres, nurse-led walk-in centres and a private hospital sector sit alongside.

Universities are close to the wards, too. A medical school sits beside the southern campus, and nursing, midwifery and allied health students train across the system, so joint clinical and academic roles are more available than the city's size would suggest.



One territory system: almost everyone in public healthcare here eventually crosses paths

1

territory-wide public health system

no competing networks to navigate

2

public hospital campuses

a tertiary campus in the south and a second in the north

Southern NSW

referral catchment

well beyond the ACT's own population

The thing that makes Canberra special clinically is its referral role. The territory is the specialist and tertiary centre for a wide stretch of southern New South Wales, from the Snowy Mountains and the South Coast to the tablelands, so trauma, cardiac, cancer, neonatal and other specialist services see a genuinely regional caseload. That gives you a case mix and complexity that a city of under half a million would not otherwise support.

Being one system also shapes working life in a lovely way. Teams know each other across campuses and disciplines, a later move between sites is an internal transfer rather than a fresh application, and good work gets noticed quickly.

REGIONAL REFERRALS

Complex work

Specialist services take referrals from across southern NSW, so the case mix runs well ahead of the territory's own population.

EASY TO MOVE WITHIN

One system to learn

One set of policies and one employer culture, with room to move between campuses and services as your career grows.

UNIVERSITIES NEARBY

Teaching and research

Medical, nursing and allied health education sits close to the wards, with joint clinical and academic roles more common than you might expect.

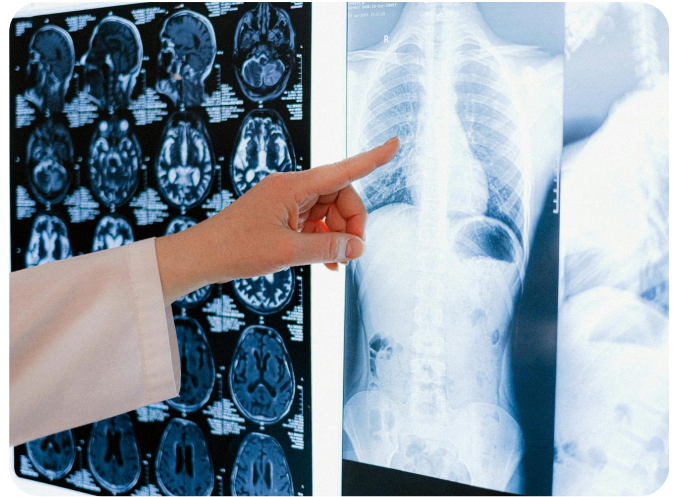
ASK IN WEEK ONE

Salary packaging

Public health roles can package part of their pay before tax. It is national practice, and well worth setting up from your first payslip.



A close-knit system where good colleagues soon become familiar faces



Specialist imaging and reporting for a catchment across southern NSW

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If your field is very specialised

Canberra has fewer sites than Sydney or Melbourne, so a highly sub-specialised career may have one main employer in the city. That suits many people well, as it means one team to grow with. If your field is narrow, tell us early and we will help you check the fit before you apply.

What to ask at interview

- ☐ Which campus is the role based at, and does rostering cross both the northern and southern campuses?
- ☐ What is the roster pattern, on-call frequency and how are penalties paid under the ACT enterprise agreement?
- ☐ How much of the caseload comes from the southern NSW referral catchment in my specialty?
- ☐ How do nurse-to-patient ratios or staffing frameworks apply on my ward or service?
- ☐ What orientation, supervision and support is there for clinicians new to Australia?
- ☐ How much salary packaging is available, and how do I set it up from day one?
- ☐ Are there links with the universities for teaching, research or postgraduate study, and is CPD time and funding provided?

Where to live in Canberra

Canberra's town-centre plan makes this a pleasant decision rather than a stressful one: you are choosing a district with its own shops, schools and character, and almost all of them are a short drive from work.

~5-10 MIN · CAFÉS AND CHARACTER

Inner north

Braddon, Dickson, O'Connor, Ainslie and Turner: walkable streets, character homes and newer apartments, Braddon's café strip and Dickson's Asian food hub, close to the northern campus.

~5-10 MIN · LEAFY AND ELEGANT

Inner south

Kingston, Griffith, Manuka, Forrest and Narrabundah: established, tree-lined streets near the lake, the embassies, the Kingston Foreshore and the southern campus.

~20 MIN · LIGHT RAIL

Gungahlin

Canberra's fastest-growing district, with newer homes, bigger blocks and light rail straight into the city. Great value and popular with young families.

~15 MIN · ESTABLISHED CENTRE

Belconnen

A large, well-serviced town centre west of the city with its own lake, a big shopping centre and a university nearby. Good value and handy for the northern campus.

~10-15 MIN · SOUTH-WEST

Woden & Weston Creek

Established suburbs with mature gardens, close to the southern campus and to the hills and nature reserves. A favourite with clinicians who want an easy commute.

~25 MIN · SPACE AND HILLS

Tuggeranong

The furthest-south district, with its own lake, full services and the best value for space. Namadgi National Park and the Murrumbidgee are on the doorstep.

~15 MIN · BRAND NEW

Molonglo Valley

Canberra's newest development front, still filling in: modern, energy-efficient homes, new parks and a growing community.

~15-20 MIN · OVER THE BORDER

Queanbeyan (NSW)

A friendly country city just over the border in New South Wales, with good-value housing and a short drive into Canberra. Many people who work in the ACT live here happily.

IF YOU WANT...	CONSIDER	BECAUSE
To walk to the lake and the city	Inner north or inner south	The original, most walkable districts, minutes from both campuses
Light rail to work	Gungahlin or the Northbourne corridor	A direct line into the city centre
Space and the hills	Tuggeranong or Weston Creek	More home for your money, close to Namadgi
An established town centre	Belconnen or Woden	Shops, services and schools all close by
A brand-new home	Molonglo Valley or Gungahlin	The newest, most energy-efficient housing
More value, short commute	Queanbeyan (NSW)	Good-value housing, a short drive in

Because distances are so short, you can choose on what you want your weekends to feel like: cafés and walkability in the inner districts, a garden and room for the children in the outer town centres, or bush and hills in the south. Many clinicians rent for six months, get to know the city, and then decide where to settle for the long term.

Before you sign a lease

- ☐ Warmth. Ask about insulation, double glazing and reverse-cycle heating; it makes all the difference on frosty winter mornings, and newer homes usually perform best.
- ☐ Your campus and your shifts. Check the drive at your actual shift times, and whether a light rail or bus route is realistic.
- ☐ The school's Priority Enrolment Area. ACT public school places are guaranteed by home address, so check the PEA for the exact address.
- ☐ Whether a short lease first suits you. Many people re-choose their district once they know the city.

Getting around Canberra

Canberra was planned for easy movement: no toll roads, light rail along a growing corridor, one of the best off-road cycle networks in Australia, and some of the shortest commutes on the mainland.

GUNGAHLIN TO THE CITY

Light rail

Light rail runs from Gungahlin down Northbourne Avenue to the city centre, and an extension south towards Woden is under way.

MYWAY+

Buses

Rapid routes link the town centres. MyWay+ covers buses and light rail, and you can tap on with a card or contactless.

OFF-ROAD PATHS

Cycling

An extensive network of off-road paths makes riding to work genuinely practical, not just a weekend pastime.

~10 MIN FROM THE CITY

The airport

Direct flights to every mainland capital and some international services; most long-haul trips connect through Sydney or Melbourne.

Canberra is an easy city to learn to drive in: wide roads, plenty of parking and no tolls anywhere in the territory. The city is famous for its roundabouts, and locals navigate by them, so it is worth brushing up on give-way rules in your first few weeks. You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for a time after arriving, then transfer to an ACT licence through Access Canberra.

Living car-free works well along the light rail corridor and in the inner districts. In Tuggeranong, Weston Creek or Queanbeyan, most households find a car makes life easier from day one.

JOURNEY	TYPICAL TIME
City → inner north or inner south	5–10 min
City → Belconnen	~15 min
City → Gungahlin	~20 min
City → Tuggeranong	~25 min
City → Queanbeyan (NSW)	~15 min

JOURNEY	TYPICAL TIME
City → Canberra Airport	~10 min
Canberra → Sydney	~3 hrs by road, or a short flight
Canberra → Melbourne	~7 hrs by road, or about an hour's flight

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In Canberra, transport is rarely the reason a day goes wrong. Choose a home near light rail, a good bus route or your own campus, and the wide, uncrowded roads do the rest.



Sydney, about three hours up the road or a short flight away: an easy weekend from Canberra

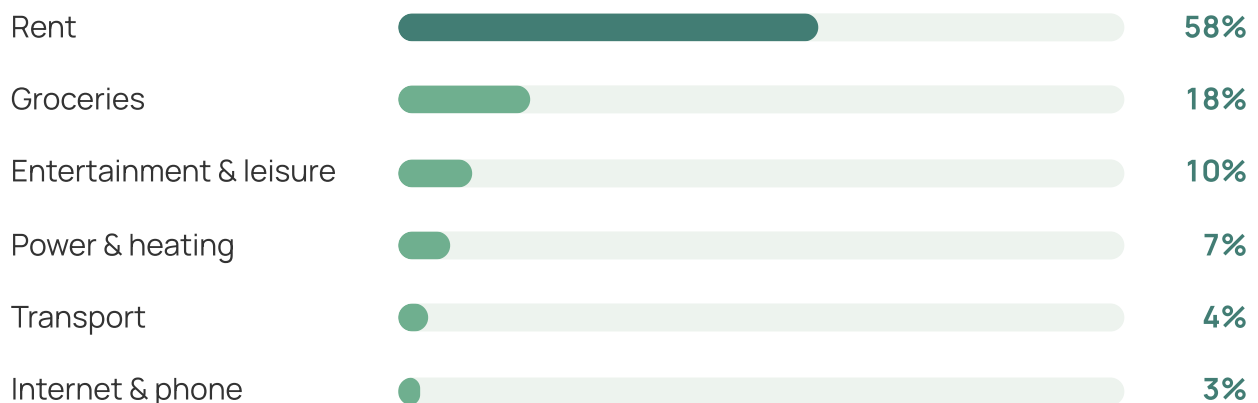
What it costs to live here

Canberra has the highest average incomes in Australia, and housing that has kept pace with them. The real advantage is how well the city's income and lifestyle go together.

It helps to read Canberra's two headline facts together. Incomes here are the highest of any Australian state or territory, and rents sit closer to Sydney's and Melbourne's than to Adelaide's or Perth's. The "regional" migration classification is about your visa pathway rather than a sign of lower costs, so plan your budget around a capital-city rent.

Where Canberra gives back is in the everyday. There are no toll roads, commutes are short, so fuel and childcare hours go further, and the lake, the reserves and the national institutions, many of them free, are the city's playground. Public health roles can also salary package part of their pay before tax.

Where a month goes



Proportions for one person on a mid-range budget, not amounts. Rent is the largest line; transport is one of the smallest of any Australian capital.

Worth planning for

- ✓ Winter heating. Frosty months make a warm, efficient home worth prioritising; a well-insulated rental can be worth a little more rent.
- ✓ A car, if you live outside the light rail corridor. Many households find one car is plenty.
- ✓ The first few weeks. Budget for temporary accommodation, a bond of up to four weeks' rent, and setting up a cosy home for winter.
- ✓ Trips to the coast and interstate. Being central means you will travel more, because so much is within reach.

WHERE THE MONEY COMES BACK

No tolls, short commutes

Less time and fuel on the road, every single day.

Free days out

The lake loop, nature reserves and many national institutions cost nothing to enjoy.

Salary packaging

Public and not-for-profit health roles can package part of their pay before tax.

GOOD TO KNOW

Capital-city rents

Housing tracks closer to Sydney and Melbourne than to the smaller capitals, balanced by Canberra's higher incomes.

Check today's numbers

Prices change every quarter, so use the comparison sites in the directory to compare Canberra with where you live now.

IN SHORT

- ✓ On a clinical salary you can live very comfortably here, with more time and less commuting than in the biggest cities.
- ✓ Plan around a capital-city rent, and choose a warm home for winter.
- ✓ Ask payroll about salary packaging in your first week.



Brunch in your own town centre: everyday treats are part of Canberra life



SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

What I tell people about Canberra

What strikes me most about Canberra is how deliberately it was made liveable. Having spent years in the NHS, I know how easily work can take over, and what stands out here is how many of the things that recharge you sit within a twenty-minute radius: the lake, the hills, the galleries, and the snow in season.

I also love what it offers clinically. One territory system with a referral reach across southern New South Wales means interesting work, colleagues who know your name and a real chance to be noticed. Don't mistake calm for quiet: ask yourself what a genuinely good week looks like to you, and Canberra tends to answer that question beautifully.

Sophie Careem

Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing



Care that has time for people: the heart of why clinicians come



Wildlife days out are a family favourite once you settle in Australia

Food, shopping and the everyday

A well-travelled population and around ninety diplomatic missions give Canberra a food scene that punches well above its size.

INNER NORTH

Braddon & Lonsdale Street

Converted warehouses full of cafés, small bars, craft brewers and brunch spots. The city's liveliest strip.

ASIAN FOOD HUB

Dickson

Some of the best-value Asian dining in the country, plus Asian grocers clustered around the town centre.

INNER SOUTH

Kingston & Manuka

Smarter dining, Italian and Mediterranean favourites, and the lakeside restaurants of the Kingston Foreshore.

WEEKENDS

Markets

The Saturday farmers' market at Exhibition Park, the Sunday Old Bus Depot Markets in Kingston, and the long-running Fyshwick fresh food markets.

The weekly shop is easy. Woolworths, Coles and ALDI cover every district, and because of the town-centre plan most people have a proper supermarket and a handful of good independents close to home rather than one central market to travel to.

For flavours of home, Canberra covers a lot of ground for its size. Asian grocers cluster in Dickson and Belconnen, halal butchers and grocers are found across several districts, and the diplomatic community supports specialist ingredients from the Middle East, South America, Africa and South-East Asia. If a particular cuisine is central to how your family eats, ask us and we will point you to the right shops.



Cool-climate wine country is part of Canberra life: the cellar doors around Murrumbateman are about forty minutes north

The rhythm of the week

- ✓ Parliament sets the pace. Cafés and restaurants are busiest in sitting weeks, and the city takes a relaxed breath over the summer break.
- ✓ A long lunch in the vines. A cellar-door lunch around Murrumbateman or Lake George is a much-loved Canberra treat.
- ✓ Weekend mornings are for markets. Locals do the Saturday farmers' market for produce, then coffee in their own town centre.
- ✓ Festivals all year. Floriade in spring, Enlighten and the National Multicultural Festival in late summer, and the autumn colour.



Dickson's Asian food hub offers some of the best-value dining in the city



Flavours of home: South Asian grocers and restaurants are easy to find



Coffee is taken seriously, in every town centre

What people do at the weekend

A lake in the middle of the city, mountains to the south, wine country to the north and the snow within a day trip: Canberra weekends are outdoors, easy and varied.

Lake Burley Griffin is less a weekend destination than the city's daily backdrop. The paths around it are used for running, cycling and walking at every hour, and the foreshore parks host everything from Floriade to picnics, markets and simply sitting in the sun.

Then there are the hills. Black Mountain, Mount Ainslie and Red Hill are inside the city, each with walking tracks and views over the lake. Further south, Namadgi National Park and Tidbinbilla Nature Reserve offer proper bushwalks, kangaroos at dusk and Aboriginal rock art sites, all within an hour of home.



The National Arboretum's Village Centre, with forests from around the world planted across the hillside

Ten weekends to start with

- ✓ The lake loop, on foot or by bike.
- ✓ The National Arboretum's forests and the view from the Village Centre.
- ✓ Braddon on a Saturday: market, coffee and a browse.
- ✓ A day on the snow at Perisher or Thredbo, in season.
- ✓ Floriade in spring, and the autumn colour in April.
- ✓ Mount Ainslie at sunset, for the whole city and the lake in one view.
- ✓ A bushwalk in Namadgi National Park or a family day at Tidbinbilla.
- ✓ A cellar-door lunch around Murrumbateman.
- ✓ Fish and chips on the water at Batemans Bay.
- ✓ The national institutions on a rainy day: the gallery, museum, war memorial and Questacon.

IN THE CITY

The lake loop

Walk, run or ride the paths around Lake Burley Griffin, or hire a kayak or paddleboard on a still morning.

~40 MIN

Tidbinbilla Nature Reserve

Wetlands, walking tracks and a sanctuary where you can see platypus, koalas and plenty of kangaroos. A favourite with children.

~45 MIN TO THE VISITOR CENTRE

Namadgi National Park

Granite peaks, high plains and Aboriginal rock art. Proper bushwalking at the edge of the city.

~40 MIN

Murrumbateman cellar doors

Cool-climate riesling and shiraz, long lunches and country views.

~2.5 HRS

The Snowy Mountains

Perisher, Thredbo and Charlotte Pass, close enough for a day trip in season. No other Australian capital is this close to the snow.

~2 HRS

Batemans Bay & the South Coast

Beaches, oysters and fish and chips on the water. Canberra's favourite weekend away.



Camping weekends are easy to fit in when the bush starts at the edge of the city



Breakfast at camp: a very Australian way to spend a weekend



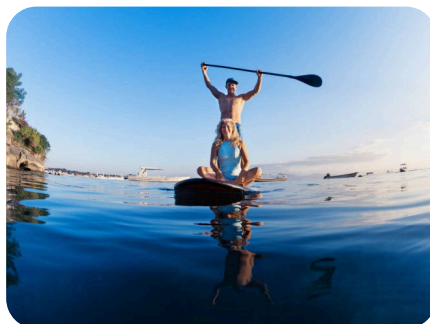
A long, relaxed lunch is a Canberra weekend tradition



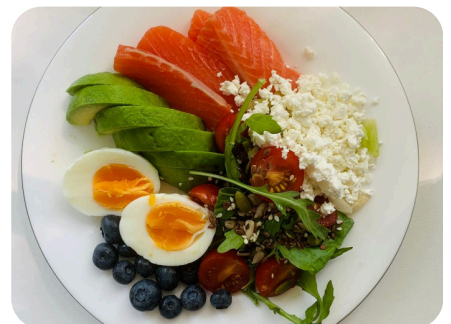
A day out among the vines



Summer weekends at the coast



Calm water and a paddleboard



Weekend brunch

Easy trips from Canberra

Sitting between the mountains and the sea, Canberra puts the snowfields, the South Coast, wine country and Sydney all within a few hours' drive.

Head south and the road climbs through the Monaro to the Snowy Mountains, home to Australia's highest peak, Mount Kosciuszko, and the ski resorts of Perisher, Thredbo and Charlotte Pass. In winter it makes a snow day trip an ordinary thing to do; in summer the same mountains offer alpine walks, wildflowers and mountain biking.

East, the Kings Highway drops down the escarpment to the NSW South Coast. Batemans Bay is about two hours away, with Broulee, Moruya and Narooma a little further south: long sandy beaches, oyster farms, quiet estuaries and the beach holiday towns that many Canberra families return to every summer.

North, the Canberra District wine region around Murrumbateman and Lake George is forty minutes away, and Sydney is about three hours up the Hume Highway, or a short flight, for the harbour, the beaches and the big-city weekends.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Batemans Bay & Broulee (NSW South Coast)	~2 hrs	The nearest beaches: swimming, surfing, oysters and fish and chips by the water. Swim between the flags at patrolled beaches.
Perisher & Thredbo (Snowy Mountains)	~2.5 hrs	The nearest ski fields to any Australian capital. Skiing and snowboarding roughly June to early October, alpine walking in summer.
Sydney	~3 hrs by road, or a short flight	The harbour, the beaches, concerts, shows and the nearest big city.
Canberra Airport	~10 min	Direct flights to every mainland capital, with long-haul connections through Sydney or Melbourne.
Murrumbateman & Lake George wineries	~35–40 min	Cool-climate riesling and shiraz, cellar doors and long lunches.
Namadgi National Park	~45 min	Bushwalking, granite peaks and Aboriginal rock art on the city's doorstep.
Narooma (NSW South Coast)	~3 hrs	A beautiful inlet town with clear water, a famous rock formation and seals around Montague Island.

GETTING TO	ROUGHLY	WHY GO
Mount Kosciuszko	~3 hrs	Walk to the top of Australia from Thredbo in summer, a gentle and unforgettable day.

~2.5 HRS · PERISHER, THREDBO

A snow day trip

Learn to ski, take a lesson with the children, or simply play in the snow and be home for dinner. Jindabyne is the friendly base town.

~2 HRS · BATEMANS BAY

The South Coast

Beaches, estuaries and holiday towns. A summer favourite, and lovely in the quieter months too.

~40 MIN · MURRUMBATEMAN

Wine country

Dozens of small cellar doors in rolling country, perfect for a weekend lunch.

~3 HRS

Sydney

Harbour, beaches, theatre and shopping. Easy to do as a weekend, or as a day trip by plane.



Broulee, on the NSW South Coast: about two hours from Canberra



Narooma's inlet and beaches, further down the NSW South Coast



Sydney Harbour, about three hours from Canberra



Canola in flower in regional New South Wales: spring drives out of Canberra are full of colour



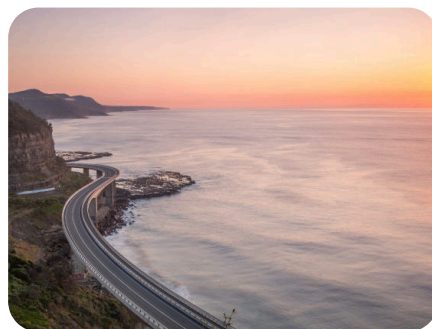
The Blue Mountains, west of Sydney: about three and a half hours from Canberra



The Illawarra coast near Wollongong, about three hours away



Kayaking on Sydney Harbour: a classic weekend in the big city



The Sea Cliff Bridge on the Grand Pacific Drive, south of Sydney



Wagga Wagga, the Riverina's largest city, about three hours west

Families and schools in Canberra

Canberra is a wonderful city to grow up in: safe streets, short distances, open space everywhere, well-regarded schools and a calendar full of free family days out.



After the bell: the school day ends mid-afternoon, leaving time for sport and the beach



Learning through play: preschool in the ACT starts early and is play-based

Canberra has three school sectors. Most children attend **government (public) schools**, run by the ACT Government. Around them sit **Catholic schools**, run by Catholic Education in the Archdiocese of Canberra and Goulburn, and a number of **independent schools**, many with a long history in the city, along with international and language-based options linked to the diplomatic community.

The ACT structure is slightly different from other states. Children attend preschool in the year before school, then kindergarten and primary school to Year 6, high school for Years 7 to 10, and a separate **college** for Years 11 and 12, where students work towards the ACT Senior Secondary Certificate. Many families find the college model gives teenagers a lovely, more grown-up start to their final years.

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School fees for temporary visa holders

In the ACT, children of most temporary visa holders pay tuition fees at public schools. Dependants of some skilled visa holders, including the 482 visa, can apply for a fee exemption when the main visa holder is working and living in the ACT. Check the ACT Government page "Enrol a child dependant of a temporary resident" (act.gov.au) for current eligibility before you arrive.

Choosing a school

- ☐ Check the Priority Enrolment Area (PEA) for the exact address before you sign a lease. Every ACT child is guaranteed a place at a public school within their PEA.
- ☐ Apply early for out-of-area, Catholic or independent schools, as popular schools fill ahead of time.
- ☐ Visit, or ask for a video call. Canberra schools are used to families arriving from overseas and from interstate.
- ☐ Ask about English language support and how the school welcomes children new to Australia.

What children tend to love here

- ☒ Questacon, the national science and technology centre, with hands-on exhibits for every age.
- ☒ Tidbinbilla's sanctuary, with platypus, koalas and kangaroos.
- ☒ The National Arboretum's huge Pod Playground and its forest views.
- ☒ Floriade in spring and the Canberra Show each February.
- ☒ Learning to ski on a family day trip to the Snowy Mountains.
- ☒ Riding bikes on the lake paths and the city's off-road cycle network.

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Early childhood

ACT public preschools offer free preschool for children in the year before kindergarten, and long day care centres across the city run preschool programmes too. The ACT also funds a free three-year-old preschool programme, though some early childhood programmes are not open to children on temporary visas, so check eligibility on the ACT Government's early childhood pages.



Kayaking and paddling on the lake are easy weekend activities for children



Early learning centres across the city welcome children from many backgrounds

ACTON · CITY CENTRE

Australian National University

One of Australia's leading research universities, with a medical school and a campus right beside the city and the lake.

BRUCE · BELCONNEN

University of Canberra

Known for nursing, midwifery, allied health and education, with strong links to the territory's health services.

CIT · SEVERAL CAMPUSES

Canberra Institute of Technology

The territory's main vocational college (TAFE), with health, community services, trades and English language courses.

DEFENCE AND FAITH-BASED STUDY

Also in the city

UNSW Canberra at the Australian Defence Force Academy, and a campus of the Australian Catholic University.



**Canberra gives you the work of a capital
and the time to actually enjoy your life.**

Your Canberra address book

Canberra is far more international than its size suggests: around ninety embassies and high commissions, two large universities and a health workforce that has welcomed overseas clinicians for years. There are well-established Indian and Malayali, Filipino, Muslim, Sikh and Jewish communities, a peak multicultural forum representing more than a hundred community groups, and one of the country's biggest multicultural festivals every February.

COUNCILS & LOCAL SERVICES

ACT Government

The territory government also acts as the local council: rubbish and recycling, libraries, pools, parks, schools and community services
act.gov.au

Access Canberra

Driver licences (including transferring an overseas licence), vehicle registration and many other territory services
 13 22 81 accesscanberra.act.gov.au

Transport Canberra

Buses, light rail, MyWay+ fares and the journey planner
transport.act.gov.au

Queanbeyan-Palerang Regional Council

The NSW council for Queanbeyan, Bungendore and Braidwood, just over the border
qprc.nsw.gov.au

healthdirect

Free 24-hour health advice from registered nurses, and a service finder for GPs and pharmacies
 1800 022 222 healthdirect.gov.au

GETTING TO KNOW THE PLACE

VisitCanberra

The official visitor site: events, Floriade, food, walks and things to do
visitcanberra.com.au

National Multicultural Festival

Canberra's big summer celebration of food, music and community from around the world
multiculturalfestival.com.au

COMMUNITY & CULTURAL ASSOCIATIONS

Canberra Multicultural Community Forum

Peak body for more than 100 multicultural community organisations in the ACT; a good starting point for finding your own community group
cmcf.org.au

MARSS Australia

Settlement services for migrants in the ACT and region, including English language classes, driving lessons, employment and tenancy help
marss.org.au

Canberra Malayalees Association

Kerala and Malayali community since the 1990s: Onam, Christmas, cultural nights, sport, Malayalam classes and help for newcomers
canberramalayalee.org

Filipino Community Council of the ACT

Umbrella body for Filipino community groups in Canberra; the Philippine Embassy in Canberra shares community news and events
philembassy.org.au

Canberra Irish Club

Irish club in Weston since 1975, with a bistro, live music, trivia and Irish cultural celebrations; a friendly first stop for UK and Irish arrivals
irishclub.com.au

National Multicultural Festival

Three-day summer festival in the city centre each February, with food stalls and performances from community groups across Canberra
multiculturalfestival.com.au

PLACES OF WORSHIP

Catholic Archdiocese of Canberra and Goulburn

Parish finder and Mass times for Catholic churches across Canberra and the region
cgcatholic.org.au

St Alphonsa Syro-Malabar Parish

Syro-Malabar Catholic parish for Canberra, Queanbeyan and the surrounding region, with several hundred families; check the Archdiocese for the current Mass venue

Anglican Diocese of Canberra and Goulburn

Find a local Anglican church anywhere in Canberra and the region
anglicancg.org.au

Canberra Baptist Church, Kingston

One of the city's oldest churches, in the inner south

Canberra Islamic Centre and Sabah Al Ahmad Mosque, Monash

Mosque in the south of the city with daily and Friday prayers and Islamic education
canberraislamiccentre.org.au

Canberra Mosque, Yarralumla

Canberra's longest-established mosque, in the inner south; there are also mosques in Spence (Belconnen) and Gungahlin

Sri Vishnu Shiva Mandir, Mawson

Hindu temple and community centre in Canberra's south, with festivals, cultural events and classes
vishnushivamandir.org.au

Canberra Sikh Association Gurdwara, Weston

Gurdwara Sahib Canberra, in Weston Creek, serving the city's growing Sikh community

ACT Jewish Community, Forrest

Orthodox and Progressive congregations at the National Jewish Memorial Centre
actjc.org.au

HALAL, KOSHER & INTERNATIONAL GROCERIES

Dickson town centre

Canberra's Asian food hub, with Asian grocers and restaurants clustered around the shops

Fyshwick Fresh Food Markets

Canberra's oldest markets, with butchers, delis and specialist food stores, Thursday to Sunday
fyshwickmarkets.com.au

ACT Jewish Community

Information on obtaining kosher food in Canberra
actjc.org.au

SUPERMARKETS & MARKETS

Woolworths

Major supermarket chain in every town centre
woolworths.com.au

Coles

Major supermarket chain in every town centre
coles.com.au

ALDI

Discount supermarket, usually the best-value full shop
aldi.com.au

IGA

Independent supermarkets in many local shopping centres
iga.com.au

Capital Region Farmers Market

More than 100 stalls of fresh produce every Saturday morning at Exhibition Park (EPIC), Mitchell
capitalregionfarmersmarket.com.au

Old Bus Depot Markets

Sunday markets in a heritage depot in Kingston: food, crafts, clothing and makers

obdm.com.au

Fyshwick Fresh Food Markets

Greengrocers, butchers, seafood, bakeries and cafés under one roof, Thursday to Sunday

fyshwickmarkets.com.au

SCHOOLS & UNIFORMS

ACT Government: find a school and enrol

Find public and non-government schools, check your Priority Enrolment Area and apply to enrol in a public school

act.gov.au

ACT Government: dependants of temporary residents

Whether school fees apply to your visa, and how skilled visa holders working in the ACT can apply for an exemption

act.gov.au

Catholic Education, Archdiocese of Canberra and Goulburn

Catholic schools and early learning centres across Canberra, with enrolment information

cg.catholic.edu.au

Association of Independent Schools of the ACT

List of independent schools in Canberra and the region

ais.act.edu.au

School uniform shops

Most Canberra schools sell uniforms through their own P&C-run uniform shop or a nominated local supplier; your school will tell you which, and second-hand sales are common

HOUSING & AREAS

Allhomes

Canberra's own long-running property site, with rentals and sales across the ACT and region

allhomes.com.au

realestate.com.au

National listings site for rentals and sales

realestate.com.au

Domain

National listings site for rentals and sales

domain.com.au

Flatmates.com.au

Rooms and shared homes, useful for your first few weeks

flatmates.com.au

ACT Government: renting

Renting rights, rental bonds (lodged with the ACT Government) and bond loan help

act.gov.au

Tenancy Advice Service ACT (Legal Aid ACT)

Free advice for renters on tenancy law, bonds and disputes

1300 654 314 legallaidact.org.au

GETTING AROUND

Transport Canberra

Buses and light rail, MyWay+ fares and the journey planner

transport.act.gov.au

Access Canberra

Driver licences, including transferring an overseas licence to an ACT licence, and vehicle registration

13 22 81 accesscanberra.act.gov.au

COST COMPARISON LINKS

Numbeo: Canberra

Crowd-sourced cost-of-living comparison; put the city you are leaving in the other box

numbeo.com/cost-of-living/in/Canberra

Expatistan: Canberra

A cleaner side-by-side comparison, useful as a second check

expatistan.com/cost-of-living/canberra

Australian Bureau of Statistics

Official figures on prices and rents, and the best guide to the direction of travel

abs.gov.au

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Checked October 2026

Community groups, shops and pages change. If a link has moved or you know a group we should add, tell us and we will update the guide.

Numbers and websites to keep handy

The national services every newcomer uses, wherever in Australia you land.

EMERGENCIES & HEALTH ADVICE

Emergency services

Police, fire and ambulance, any time
000

Emergency from a mobile

Also connects to emergency services from any mobile phone
112

healthdirect

Free 24/7 health advice from a registered nurse
1800 022 222 [healthdirect.gov.au](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au)

Lifeline

24/7 crisis support and suicide prevention, by phone, text or chat
13 11 14 [lifeline.org.au](https://www.lifeline.org.au)

Poisons Information Centre

24/7 advice if someone may have been poisoned
13 11 26

Pregnancy, Birth and Baby

Free support for parents from pregnancy to preschool
1800 882 436 [pregnancybirthbaby.org.au](https://www.pregnancybirthbaby.org.au)

Private health insurance complaints

The Commonwealth Ombudsman's free complaints service
1300 737 299 [ombudsman.gov.au](https://www.ombudsman.gov.au)

VISAS, REGISTRATION & WORK

Department of Home Affairs

Visas, skilled occupation lists and processing times
immi.homeaffairs.gov.au

ImmiAccount

Lodge and track your visa application online
online.immi.gov.au

Register of migration agents (OMARA)

Check an agent is registered before you pay
mara.gov.au

Ahpra

National registration and the National Boards
1300 419 495 [ahpra.gov.au](https://www.ahpra.gov.au)

Fair Work Ombudsman

Awards, pay rates and your rights at work
13 13 94 [fairwork.gov.au](https://www.fairwork.gov.au)

HEALTHCARE FOR YOUR FAMILY

Medicare · Services Australia

Enrolment, cards, claims and reciprocal health care agreements
132 011 [servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare](https://www.servicesaustralia.gov.au/medicare)

healthdirect service finder

Find a GP, pharmacy, urgent care or hospital near you
[healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services](https://www.healthdirect.gov.au/australian-health-services)

privatehealth.gov.au

Compare private health cover independently; run by the Commonwealth Ombudsman
[privatehealth.gov.au](https://www.privatehealth.gov.au)

SCHOOLS & CHILDCARE

NSW school finder

Government schools and catchments in New South Wales
[education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder](https://www.education.nsw.gov.au/school-finder)

Find my school (Victoria)

School zones for any Victorian address
[findmyschool.vic.gov.au](https://www.findmyschool.vic.gov.au)

Find a school (Queensland)

State schools and catchment areas
qld.gov.au/education/schools/find

Find a public school (WA)

Western Australian public schools and local-intake areas
wa.gov.au/service/education-and-training/school-education/find-public-school

School zones (South Australia)

Zone maps for government schools
education.sa.gov.au/parents-and-families/enrol-school-or-preschool/zones-catchments-and-capacity-management/maps-school-zones-enrolment-year

Find your local school (Tasmania)

Intake areas for Tasmanian government schools
decyp.tas.gov.au/learning/find-your-local-school

Priority enrolment areas (ACT)

Find a Canberra public school for your address
act.gov.au/education-and-training/find-a-school-and-enrol

Choose a school (NT)

Urban and remote schools in the Northern Territory
nt.gov.au/learning/primary-and-secondary-students/choose-a-school

Starting Blocks

Compare childcare services and quality ratings near you
startingblocks.gov.au

Child Care Subsidy

Eligibility, rates and how to apply
servicesaustralia.gov.au/child-care-subsidy

MONEY & HOME

Australian Taxation Office

Apply for your tax file number (TFN), tax and super
13 28 61 ato.gov.au

Moneysmart

Free, independent budgeting, super and banking tools
moneysmart.gov.au

SETTLING IN

TIS National

Free interpreting by phone, 24/7, in 150+ languages
131 450 tisnational.gov.au

Settle in Australia

Home Affairs' settlement topics and services for new arrivals
immi.homeaffairs.gov.au/settling-in-australia

MyAus app

Government app to help newcomers find services, in many languages
myausapp.com

Overseas drivers (Austroads)

How overseas licences are recognised, with links to each state's licensing authority
austroads.gov.au/drivers-and-vehicles/overseas-drivers/country-recognition



Always check the source

Rules, fees and services change. Treat these as starting points and confirm details with the organisation. Ethicare are recruitment specialists, not registered migration agents.

Six steps, and someone beside you for each one

Moving country is a sequence of decisions. We take them with you in order, so you are never solving step five before step two is done.



STEP 1

Discovery call

A relaxed conversation about your profession, your family and what you want from a move. No forms, no pressure.



STEP 2

Eligibility & registration

We map your route to Ahpra registration and help you gather the evidence the regulator will ask for.



STEP 3

Opportunities & interviews

Roles matched to where you want to live and how you like to work, with honest briefings before every interview.



STEP 4

Offer & decision support

We help you read the offer properly: pay step, relocation support, roster and what the team is really like.



STEP 5

Visa & relocation guidance

Practical guidance on visas, shipping, pets, schools and the first weeks, so nothing arrives as a surprise.



STEP 6

Settling in

We stay in touch after you land, from your first week on the ward to your first winter.



— READY TO EXPLORE OPPORTUNITIES?

Picture yourself in Canberra. Then let's make it real.

Tell us what you do and where you would like to live. We will come back with roles that fit, a clear view of the registration route, and time to answer every question.



Ethicare Resourcing

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